Gerda and the Snow Queen



A bedtime story for ages 4–7



In a little town with red rooftops lived two best friends, Gerda and Kai, who shared a garden full of roses.



Every summer morning they played among the roses, smelling sweet flowers and chasing butterflies in the warm sun. "Best friends forever," said Gerda. "Forever and ever," said Kai, and pinky-promised beneath the biggest rosebush.



Then winter came, soft and white, and the roses slept under the snow. One sparkling afternoon, a sleigh pulled by white horses glided down the street, and in it sat the Snow Queen in a dress that shimmered like fresh snow.

"Come and see my palace of ice," she said, in a voice like wind chimes. "It has shining towers and frozen fountains — but it is so quiet there, all alone."



Kai had never seen a palace of ice. He climbed in, and away they flew over snowy fields and frozen lakes, far to the north.

But the palace was so cold and so quiet that, little by little, Kai forgot the warm sun, the roses, and even his best friend.

When Kai did not come home, Gerda put on her red coat and woolly hat. "I will find Kai," she said. "Best friends do not give up."



First she came to a little house where flowers bloomed even in winter, and a kind old woman gave her warm soup and a soft bed and listened to her whole story. "Follow the river," said the old woman. "It knows the way north."



Gerda followed the river past tall pine trees to a palace, where a kind princess gave her warm boots, a golden sleigh, and a black raven to show her the way.



The raven flew with her over dark forests and frozen lakes, until at last they saw a palace of ice, shining blue in the moonlight.



Inside, Kai sat alone in a great cold hall, making pictures out of pieces of ice, his hands cold and his smile gone away.



"I'm here, Kai," whispered Gerda, running to him and wrapping her arms around him, tight and warm. "I found you."

As she held him, warm tears fell on his cold cheeks — and the cold melted away. Kai blinked, and remembered the roses, the summer sun, and his best friend.

"Kai?" said Gerda, smiling through her tears. "Kai!" said Kai, hugging her back.

The Snow Queen watched from her icy window, and for the first time in a long while, she smiled — because even a palace of ice feels warmer when someone is loved.



They rode home in the golden sleigh, and the whole town came out to welcome them. That night they slept safe and warm, side by side, dreaming of summer.

Sleep now, little Gerda.

The end. ■